

# China Arrival Checklist

Your First 24 Hours in China, Stress-Free

*By ChinaTripBox.com*

- [OK] Which eSIM to buy before you land
- [OK] How to install Alipay + link your foreign card
- [OK] How to set up WeChat Pay step by step
- [OK] How to call a DiDi from the airport
- [OK] How to buy a metro ticket with your phone
- [OK] Quick reference checklist at the end

## Before You Land (48 Hours Before)

The single biggest mistake first-time visitors make is waiting until they arrive in China to set things up. Most essential apps require verification that takes 5-15 minutes, and you don't want to be doing that on a slow airport WiFi connection while jet-lagged.

### Step 1: Buy an eSIM (15 minutes)

Before your flight, install an eSIM so you have data the moment you land in China. This is non-negotiable -- you need internet access to verify app accounts, load maps, and call your ride. Recommended providers: Airalo (global brand, 1GB/7 days from \$4.50), Holafly (unlimited data from \$19), or Nomad (competitive per-GB pricing). Make sure to activate the eSIM before departure -- most activate upon first connection to a Chinese network.

Alternative: If your phone doesn't support eSIM, pre-order a physical SIM from China Mobile or China Unicom at airport counters. Beijing Capital Airport (PEK) has a China Mobile counter in Terminal 3 arrival hall. Pudong Airport (PVG) has both carriers in T1 and T2. A tourist SIM with 20GB costs CNY50-CNY100 (about \$7-\$14).

#### PRO TIP

Save a screenshot of your eSIM QR code before you fly. Airport WiFi can be slow or require a local SMS to connect.

### Step 2: Install Alipay (10 minutes)

Download Alipay from the App Store or Google Play BEFORE you fly (the app is ~200MB). Register with your email or phone number. Go to 'Me' \-> 'Settings' \-> 'Accounts' \-> 'Add Bank Card' or 'Add International Card'. You need your passport for verification.

Supported cards: Visa, Mastercard, Amex from most countries. China UnionPay cards also work. Alipay charges a ~3% fee on international card transactions above \$200. For small payments (coffee, snacks, metro), the fee is waived.

#### PRO TIP

Link your card at home on WiFi. If verification fails, try a different card--Visa works better than Amex in most cases.

### Step 3: Install WeChat Pay (10 minutes)

WeChat is China's super-app. Download it, register, then go to 'Me' \-> 'Services' \-> 'Wallet' \-> 'Add Card'. WeChat Pay supports foreign Visa/Mastercard since 2023. You'll need to verify with your passport--take a clear photo of the data page.

Key difference: WeChat Pay is more widely accepted at restaurants and small shops than Alipay, but Alipay has better English support and a simpler setup. Most people use both.

## Arrival at the Airport

### Step 4: Connect to WiFi

Chinese airports offer free WiFi, but many require SMS verification. If your eSIM is already active, skip to step 5. If not, look for 'Airport WiFi - Free' SSID. Some airports (Shanghai Pudong, Beijing Daxing) now offer WeChat-based WiFi login. Open WeChat, scan the QR code at the WiFi stand, and you're connected in 10 seconds.

**PRO TIP**

If you can't get WiFi, find the China Mobile/Unicom counter in the arrival hall. They'll help you activate a SIM on the spot.

### Step 5: Get to Your Hotel

You have three options from any major Chinese airport:

- DiDi (China's Uber): Open Alipay \-> 'Travel' tab \-> 'DiDi'. Enter your destination in English. Pay via linked card. Cost from PVG to Lujiazui: ~CNY150 (\$20).
- Metro: Follow airport signage to the metro station. Buy a single-trip ticket at the machine\--most have English menus. Pay with Alipay QR code or cash. Cost: CNY5-CNY10 (\$0.70-\$1.40).
- Taxi: Follow 'Taxi' signs. Show your hotel name in Chinese on your phone. Pay with cash or QR code. Cost: typically 50-100% more than DiDi.

**PRO TIP**

Save your hotel address in Chinese in your Notes app before you fly. Show it to the driver or paste it into DiDi. This saves 10 minutes of confusion at arrivals.

# Your First 24 Hours

## Step 6: Essential App Setup

Once you're at your hotel on WiFi, finish the remaining setup:

- DiDi: Already works through Alipay. No separate app needed unless you want English notifications.
- Metro QR: In Alipay \-> 'Transport' \-> select your city. Activate the metro card. Scan QR at metro gates. No physical card needed.
- Maps: Apple Maps works in major cities. Google Maps is partially blocked. Download Amap (Gaode) or Baidu Maps as backup.
- Translation: Download Google Translate offline pack (Chinese) or use Apple Translate. Both work without VPN for basic phrases.
- VPN (optional): If you need Instagram, WhatsApp calls, Google, or YouTube, set up a VPN before you leave or use an eSIM that routes through Hong Kong (Airalo Asia plan).

### PRO TIP

Test your metro QR code at a station near your hotel first. Some new users need 5-10 minutes to figure out which gate accepts QR scans (look for the scanner with a screen).

## Quick Reference: 24-Hour Checklist

- ☐ eSIM activated and working
- ☐ Alipay installed + card linked
- ☐ WeChat Pay installed + card linked
- ☐ Hotel WiFi password saved
- ☐ DiDi tested (set a destination)
- ☐ Metro QR activated for your city
- ☐ VPN installed and tested (if needed)
- ☐ Cash withdrawn: CNY500-1000 from airport ATM
- ☐ Hotel address saved in Chinese
- ☐ Emergency numbers saved (110 police, 120 ambulance)

That's it. These steps take about 45 minutes total if you do them in order. The difference between a smooth first day and a frustrating one is simply knowing what to do first.